Pegasus: Probabilistic Performance Guarantees for Agentic Provisioning of Software Services

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***Abstract*—**

***Index Terms*—Performance Guarantees, Service Quality, Gaussian Processes, Performance Modeling, Service Composition**

I. Introduction

Large Language Models (LLMs) have risen as universal interpretation and generation engines for text-based contents, introducing a major disruption for software development [7]. Traditionally, computing services were developed manually according to stakeholder requirements, and operated in close-loop controls to continuously meet operational thresholds. Within that context, LLMs appeared as a fast and cost-efficient enabler for autonomous software development and deployment, opening new branches of service research [2]: automatic generation [6], [14] and recomposition [22] of software services. The combined vision from these works is a *future internet*, where agents aim to continuously satisfy high-level user intents by generating, composing, and reconfiguring software applications and their services [1].

Traditional service-oriented architectures already provide clear roles and interfaces to operate such systems [23]: the service provider and the service consumer establish Service Level Agreements (SLAs) that specify the expected quality through measurable Service Level Objectives (SLOs). In this future internet, applications will be tailored to individual clients and their SLOs [25]. However, creating this vast space of possible application also means that potential compositions or configurations will often lack end-to-end benchmarks *prior to deployment*. It is neither possible nor cost-efficient to benchmark this search space exhaustively before offering a solution to a consumer; hence, service providers require probabilistic models for providing guarantees about the quality of different service compositions and configurations before deployment.

Applications themselves can be recomposed into systems of systems [21]; to decrease the overall complexity, individual systems (or services) must provide clear interfaces and guarantees. So suppose we need to ensure that one system's latency is below a threshold, it is not enough to *estimate* that the tail latency (e.g., the P_{99} percentile) will be below the threshold, but the application must *guarantee* this with a certain probability. To avoid SLA violations, providers could simply give increasingly conservative performance estimates, which could only be fulfilled by provisioning more resources, increasing the price for the consumer, and wasting the provider's resources. The challenge is thus to make the performance guarantee as *tight* as possible. For a service composition S, also called an application, with topology $\{s_1 \rightarrow s_2 \rightarrow \dots\}$, a provider needs to be able to accurately answer the following questions:

- What performance could we guaranteed for this application, before conducting any end-to-end benchmark?
- What performance could we guarantee if we replaced a service (e.g., s_1) with another one (e.g., s_x) that was not benchmarked end-to-end in this exact application?
- What performance could we guarantee if we reconfigured an individual service (e.g., s_1) to a configuration that was not benchmarked end-to-end in this application?

While composition and configuration are operationally decoupled—services can be reconfigured without altering the topology, and vice versa—they are logically entangled: estimating composite performance requires understanding individual service dynamics under limited empirical observations. Optimization techniques like branch-and-bound can reduce the candidate space, but evaluating candidate solutions remains the core bottleneck. Learning-based optimizers must contend with varying degrees of empirical evidence, ranging from well-observed service instances to completely unseen configurations and compositions.

TODO: Add summary paragraph introducing the contribution/solution: State the gap in existing work (e.g., deterministic code contracts vs. black-box microservices) and summarize the proposed PPG framework combining SVGPs and Stochastic Network Calculus.

II. Preliminaries

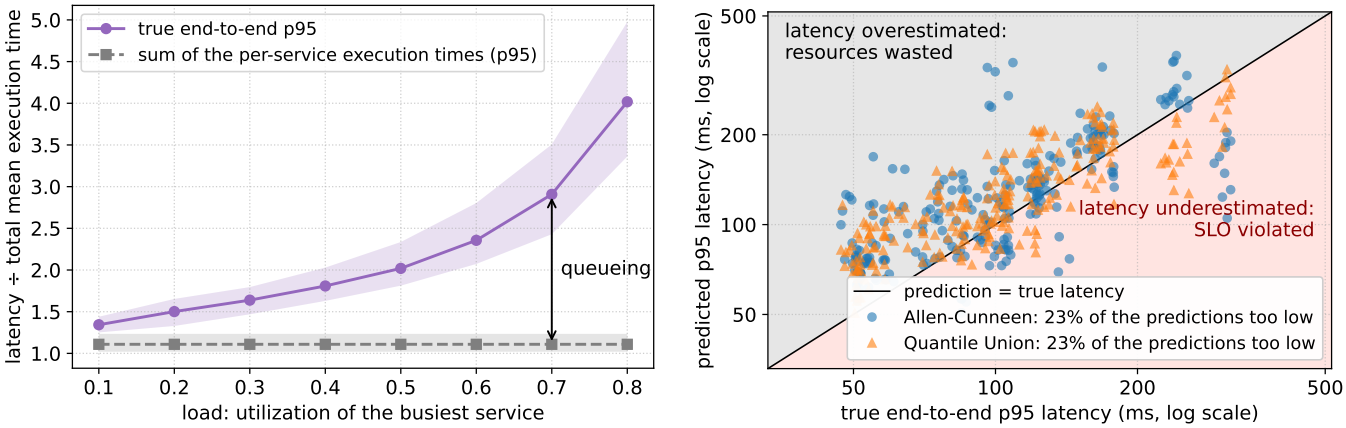
A. Motivating Example

Consider a customer that requests a real-time drone monitoring application, which can be structured as a four-stage pipeline: (1) video stream ingestion from the drone, (2) object detection along the trajectory, (3) trajectory adjustment calculation, and (4) telemetry reporting to an external traffic planner. Logically, this application is composed of multiple connected microservices $S = \{s_1 \rightarrow s_2 \rightarrow s_3 \rightarrow s_4\}$.

Each service in this application can be configured along multiple dimensions, such as allocated hardware resources

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(a) Per-service execution times do not add up to the tail latency.

(b) An accurate prediction is not a guarantee

Fig. 1. Composing per-service performance models does not yield an end-to-end guarantee (computer vision application under Poisson arrivals from Section V). **(a)** True end-to-end P_{95} and the sum of the per-service P_{95} execution times, both divided by the total mean execution time of the chain, against the utilization of the busiest service; lines show the median and bands the interquartile range over the configurations. **(b)** Predicted versus true P_{95} at utilization 0.5 (5 training sets, 240 predictions per method) for a queueing formula on learned execution times (*Allen-Cunneen* [4]) and learned per-service latency quantiles (*Quantile Union*); the legend gives the share of predictions below the true latency.

(e.g., CPU cores) and internal service parameters (e.g., object detection model resolution or batch size). While these configuration knobs dictate execution time, the customer is solely interested in end-to-end *performance* (e.g., total latency ≤ 100 ms) and overall *cost* (e.g., minimize resources).

Furthermore, external systems like the traffic planner pose strict workload bounds, e.g., updates must arrive consistently every 100 ms. Adhering to these bounds in distributed systems typically relies on reporting high-percentile tail latencies (e.g., P_{90} or P_{99}). However, the specified application topology and configuration have not been executed and benchmarked end-to-end so far; the provider only has measurements of the individual services, collected in isolation or in another existing applications. The following section shows why these measurements alone do not yield the required guarantee.

B. Research Questions

Figure 1 shows why naive analysis and composition of service observations fail to guarantee performance, and motivates the two research questions that this paper addresses. The application is a chain of three computer vision services from our testbed in Section V, each configurable in its number of service replicas and quality knobs (e.g., input resolution, model size). For each of the 50 measured configurations of the chain, we replay the per-item execution times measured at every service through FIFO queues, with Poisson arrivals at a rate that keeps the busiest service busy for a given share of the time (its utilization). All models are trained only on runs of the services alone or in other chains, never on this chain.

Composing Tail Latencies under Load. The end-to-end latency of an item is the sum of its execution times *plus* the time it waits in the queue of every service. This waiting time cannot be observed at an individual service: it depends on how irregularly items enter the application (the external arrival process), on how each service releases items to the next one (the internal composition), and on how close each service runs to its capacity (the load). Figure 1a shows that even the sum of the per-service P_{95} execution times underestimates the end-to-end P_{95} at every load, and that the gap grows with the load, so it cannot be corrected by a constant factor. Benchmarking every candidate composition end-to-end would capture this queueing [19], but, as argued in the introduction, the space of compositions and configurations is too large to benchmark before deployment. **Question #1:** The open research question is therefore how to derive the end-to-end tail latency of a composition, including its queueing, purely from observations of individual services and a description of the workload.

Guarantees for Unseen Configurations. An SLO requires a latency bound that is exceeded with at most a given probability; however, performance models are fitted to be accurate [8], [27], i.e., *close* to the measured value on average, but not necessarily above it. For a configuration that was never observed, such a prediction can err in either direction: an overestimated latency wastes resources, an underestimated one violates the SLO. Figure 1b shows that two predictors that account for queueing, trained only on observations of individual services, overestimate the latency for most unseen configurations but underestimate it for a sizable share. Even quantile predictors [13] give no indication of whether a configuration is well covered by observations or far away from all of them. **Question #2:** The open research question is therefore how to turn limited evidence about each service into an end-to-end bound that holds with a stated probability, and that becomes more conservative where evidence is missing.

C. Background and Related Work

TODO: To improve the flow, we must split this section: background stays here, and RW goes to the paper's end

We have grouped related work by how it obtains the performance of an application: (1) analytical models derive it from a formal description of the system, (2) learned models fit it to

measurements of the entire application, and (3) compositional models assemble it from models of the individual services. For each group, we explain *how* it models performance and *why* it leaves the presented research challenges open.

1) Analytical Performance Models: Queueing theory is a classical tool for relating workload and capacity to response time [15]. For instance, Gandhi et al. [12] model the performance of individual servers as M/G/1 queues[1], and use this model for finding a power allocation that minimizes overall response time. Layered Queueing Networks [10] extend queueing networks to software services that hold one resource while waiting for another, as in nested client–server calls. Both target mean response times in steady state rather than tail probabilities (Challenge #2). Network calculus bounds delays instead of averaging them: Duan [5] describes network and compute services through latency–rate capability profiles, merges these profiles into one end-to-end profile, and derives the maximum delay of the composite service. This bound is deterministic, i.e., it covers the worst case and thus becomes overly conservative for services with variable execution times; Stochastic Network Calculus (SNC) [9], on which we build, instead bounds the *probability* of exceeding a given delay. SNC assumes that the MGFs of arrivals and service exist; an extension to heavy-tailed traffic replaces them by power-law envelopes at the price of considerably looser bounds [20].

Closest in spirit, Iyer et al. [16] compute *performance contracts* for software network functions without executing them: symbolic analysis of the source code yields conservative upper bounds on the memory accesses and execution cycles per packet, expressed as functions of workload-dependent variables; contracts for chains of network functions are computed recursively. As with worst-case execution time analysis [28], this requires access to the source code, whereas microservices are typically deployed as opaque containers. Moreover, these contracts bound the processing effort per packet, not waiting time that accumulates under load (Challenge #1).

Common to all analytical models is that their parameters (e.g., service rates, branching probabilities, or code paths) must be supplied for the exact system under study. None of them expresses how reliable a prediction is for a configuration that was never measured (Challenge #2).

2) Learning Models of Entire Applications: A second line of work treats the application as one big black box and learns its end-to-end performance from empirical measurements; we call this the *top-down* approach. *Ernest* [27] fits a small parametric model to short profiling runs of an analytics job on samples of the input data, and extrapolates the running time to larger datasets and clusters. *CherryPick* [3] replaces the fixed model structure with a Gaussian Process (GP) and uses its confidence intervals to choose the next cloud configuration to benchmark; the search stops as soon as the model can identify the best configuration. *Microscaler* [31] similarly combines Bayesian optimization (BO) with a heuristic to find the number of instances at which a microservice meets its SLA. Production systems are more conservative: Google's *Autopilot* [24] sets resource limits from moving-window statistics of past usage plus a safety margin, optionally choosing among many such window models by their historical cost.

Top-down models are simple in the sense that they require no knowledge of the application's internal structure: a single model maps the configuration to the end-to-end performance. This is also their limitation: replacing a service or changing the topology changes the modeled function itself, so the end-to-end performance must be benchmarked again (Challenge #1). Furthermore, where uncertainty is modeled at all, as in *CherryPick*, it steers the search towards a good configuration but is not converted into a latency guarantee (Challenge #2).

3) Compositional Models: The *bottom-up* alternative predicts the quality of a composition from its constituent services, which has a long tradition in service-oriented computing. Gallotti et al. [11] translate activity diagrams into stochastic models for a probabilistic model checker; the execution time and reliability of each service are annotations supplied at design time. Wu et al. [30] use a hidden Markov model to predict whether a composition of Cloud services will satisfy the requested QoS, and Fanjiang et al. [8] evolve time-series predictors that forecast the QoS of web services. Geebelen et al. [13] come closest to a guarantee: a Petri-net simulation merges the monitored response times of the elementary services into a time series of the composition, and a kernel-based quantile estimator with an online offset correction predicts the quantile named in the SLO, such that the violation frequency converges to the agreed level. None of these works, however, learns QoS as a function of resource allocation, service configuration, and arrival rate. They can assess compositions of services as currently deployed, but not a composition that involves a configuration without observations; likewise, the guarantee of Geebelen et al. holds asymptotically in the number of observations (Challenge #2).

Fluxion [19] is the closest learned counterpart to our work. It trains one model per service (e.g., a deep neural network or a GP) that maps the service's configuration knobs, its observed states, and the latency percentiles of its downstream services to a latency percentile of the service itself. These models are chained into an inference graph that mirrors the service dependencies; after a service is scaled or replaced, only the model of that service is retrained. However, the inference graph propagates point estimates: Fluxion is evaluated by its mean absolute error, and its authors note that prediction errors accumulate along the graph in a way that is not trivial to derive analytically. A predicted P_{90} can therefore err in either direction, and the output does not reveal any uncertainty about whether a service model was queried at a configuration it has never seen (Challenge #2).

D. Summary

In summary, analytical models compose rigorously but need access to parameters (e.g., source code); top-down approaches can wrap around black-box applications, but this prevents

[1]Note that M implies a *Markovian* (or Poisson) arrival process, G a *General* service time distribution, i.e., described through a mean and variance, and $c = 1$ indicates a single server. *Pegasus* supports a wider range of arrival processes and multi-server queues with $c \geq 1$, but assumes a sub-Gaussian service process (e.g., Gaussian or bounded execution times).

generalization to unseen topologies; and existing compositional models propagate predictions without any degree of uncertainty. *Pegasus* (our approach) combines the strengths of these approaches: it learns the execution time distribution of each black-box service from local observations, including the epistemic uncertainty for unseen configurations, and composes per-service models into a probabilistic bound on the end-to-end latency for unseen service compositions.

III. Problem Definition

A. System Model

We model a service composition S, also called an application, as a Directed Acyclic Graph (DAG) with available microservices (vertices) $V = \{s_1, s_2, \ldots, s_n\}$, where directed edges $E \subseteq V \times V$ represent the paths along which items (e.g., requests or data frames) are passed on. For a sequential pipeline, this simplifies to $S = \{s_1 \to s_2 \to \cdots \to s_n\}$ with $n = |S|$ services.

Services. Each service $s_i \in V$ consists of c_i instances, where all instances share one configuration $x_i = \langle r_i, \kappa_i \rangle$, where

- $r_i \in \mathcal{R}_i$ are the global resource allocations (e.g., CPU quota, memory limit) across all service instances,
- $\kappa_i \in \mathcal{K}_i$ are its software configuration knobs (e.g., model size, data quality) unified across all instances, and
- $c_i \in \mathbb{N}$ is the number of servers/workers for s_i.

A service processes up to c_i items at a time, one per worker, in the order of arrival; items that arrive while the service is busy wait in its queue. The *execution time* Y_i of s_i is the time (in seconds) from the start to the end of processing one item. Due to runtime variability (e.g., thread scheduling, input size), Y_i is a random variable whose unknown distribution $P_{Y_i|x_i}$ depends on the configuration of the service. The *latency* of an item at s_i is its waiting time in the queue plus its execution time, $W_i = Q_i + Y_i$.

For each service, empirical evidence is available only as a sparse dataset of execution times observed at N_i configurations, $\mathcal{D}_i = \{(x_i^{(j)}, y_i^{(j)})\}_{j=1}^{N_i}$, collected while the service ran in isolation or within other compositions. This means that large regions of the configuration space $\mathcal{R}_i \times \mathcal{K}_i$ remain unobserved; likewise, only a small share of all possible service compositions $(V \times V)^n$ have been benchmarked end-to-end.

Workload. Items enter the composition at its first service according to an *external arrival process*, which we describe by the gap T (in seconds) between two consecutive arrivals. We define the mean arrival rate λ (items per second) as

$$\lambda = \frac{1}{\mathbb{E}[T]}, \tag{1}$$

and the variability of the arrivals C_a^2 through the squared coefficient of variation as

$$C_a^2 = \frac{\mathrm{Var}(T)}{\mathbb{E}[T]^2}. \tag{2}$$

An item that leaves a service immediately enters the next one, so every downstream service receives the departures of its predecessor.

TODO: Place the utilization formula somewhere

$$\rho_i = \frac{\lambda \times m_i}{c_i} \tag{3}$$

Probabilistic Performance Guarantees. Let D_S denote the end-to-end latency in a composition S under the configuration vector $\mathbf{x} = (x_1, \ldots, x_K)$, i.e., the time an item spends from its external arrival until it leaves the last service. Given a maximum permissible violation probability $\epsilon \in (0, 1)$ specified in an SLO, a latency bound d_S must satisfy

$$\mathbb{P}\left(D_S > d_S\right) \leq \epsilon, \tag{4}$$

which means that d_S is an upper bound on the $(1-\epsilon)$ quantile of the end-to-end latency.

TODO: Example with some values

Because the execution-time distributions are only known through models learned from $\mathcal{D}_1, \ldots, \mathcal{D}_n$, Eq. (4) cannot be asserted with certainty. A *Probabilistic Performance Guarantee* (PPG) therefore has two parameters: the violation probability ϵ, which covers the variability between items, and a confidence level $\gamma \in (0, 1)$, which covers the uncertainty of the learned models. A PPG is a latency bound $d_S(\mathbf{x}, \epsilon, \gamma)$ for which Eq. (4) holds with confidence γ.

B. Problem Statement.

Given a composition S, a configuration vector $\mathbf{x}$, an external arrival process, a violation probability ϵ, and a confidence level γ, derive the PPG $d_S(\mathbf{x}, \epsilon, \gamma)$ in a *zero-shot manner*, i.e., purely from the per-service datasets $\{\mathcal{D}_1, \ldots, \mathcal{D}_K\}$ and without any end-to-end measurement of S. The bound should be as tight as possible, since every unit of slack translates into over-provisioned resources.

C. Foundational Assumptions

To obtain performance bounds for black-box service compositions without end-to-end measurements, our framework makes the following assumptions about the domain:

1) *Performance Isolation:* Services run in isolated execution environments (e.g., containers with strict CPU and memory limits), and the CPU quota per service suffices for executing all its workers without throttling. The execution time of a service is therefore affected neither by co-located services nor by its own load.
2) *Multi-Server FIFO Services:* Every service has c_i workers that share one unbounded queue and process items in the order of their arrival (i.e., FIFO). For constructing the bound, we assume that a worker receives every c_i-th item (*cyclic assignment*), turning it into a single-server queue whose gap between two items is the sum of c_i consecutive inter-arrival times. Cyclic assignment can only increase the waiting time [29]; hence, upper bounds under cyclic assignment also hold for shared queues.
3) *Load-Independent Execution Times:* The distribution of the execution time Y_i depends only on the configuration x_i; thus, Y_i depends neither on the arrival process nor on the services before s_i, and the execution times of different items at s_i are independent. This allows

execution times observed in isolation, or in a different composition, to be reused for unseen compositions.

4) *Sub-Gaussian Execution Times:* The moment-generating function (MGF) of the execution time Y_i is bounded by that of a Gaussian with mean $m_i = \mathbb{E}[Y_i]$ and variance proxy σ_i^2, both depending on x_i, for all $\theta > 0$:

$$M_{Y_i}(\theta) = \mathbb{E}\left[e^{\theta Y_i}\right] \leq \exp\left(\theta\, m_i + \frac{\theta^2}{2}\,\sigma_i^2\right). \quad (5)$$

This holds, e.g., for Gaussian and for bounded execution times; heavier tails are discussed in Section VI-A.

5) *Renewal Arrivals:* The gaps T between external arrivals are independent, identically distributed (i.i.d.), and independent of the execution times, and their Laplace transform $\mathbb{E}[e^{-\theta T}]$ is known. This covers, for instance, Poisson arrivals, periodic arrivals with jitter, and gamma-distributed gaps of any C_a^2.

6) *Arrivals Inside the Composition:* The framework does not model the departure process of a service explicitly. A service that is not the first of the composition is bounded as if it received the external arrival process, refined by the minimum spacing that its predecessor enforces between two departures (Section IV-B). This is conservative when the external arrivals are at least as variable as the execution times, as with Poisson arrivals; for nearly periodic arrivals combined with highly variable execution times and high utilization, the departures of a service can be burstier than the external arrivals.

TODO: Decide after the prototype: keep this assumption, or replace it with a proven bound on the departures (looser). It is also too implementation specific

Independence between the execution times of an item at *different* services is not assumed in general; it is only required by one of the two composition variants (Section IV-C).

IV. Pegasus Framework

Link to Pegasus repo

TODO: Way too long. Shorten especially the intro, but also the subsections, and try to remove some equations.

Given an application that consists of $|S|$ services, our methodology derives a Probabilistic Performance Guarantee (PPG) for S. Such a PPG characterizes the performance of a service or service composition together with its inherent runtime variability and the uncertainty resulting from limited empirical evidence. Conceptually, a PPG can be established for individual services (i.e., a single-service pipeline with $|S| = 1$); these local bounds are then composed into end-to-end performance guarantees for multi-service pipelines. Notably, a PPG does not prescribe any optimization objective or algorithm. Instead, it provides a fundamental performance guarantee that enables downstream frameworks to optimize for objectives such as latency, throughput, or cost.

Our methodology consists of three main steps, as depicted in Figure 2: (1) learning a probabilistic model of the execution time of each individual service from empirical observations, (2) deriving a latency bound for each service from its model and the workload, and (3) composing these bounds into a PPG for the complete service pipeline. The first step is the only one that requires data, and it only requires data of the individual services. Everything that depends on the composition, i.e., which services follow each other and how many items arrive, enters analytically in the second and third step. This separation is what makes the guarantee available for compositions that were never executed.

A. Learning

The first step trains, for each service s_i, a probabilistic model that predicts the execution time Y_i of an item from the service configuration x_i. Two constraints apply to this step: (1) the scaling behavior of services is rarely linear [3], e.g., performance saturates after providing sufficient RAM, and (2) services live in containers, whose source code can rarely be analyzed to make assumptions about their functional behavior. Gaussian Processes (GPs) satisfy both constraints, as they are non-parametric and do not impose a structure on the learned function.

Each service model is an exact GP with a Matérn-5/2 kernel and an additive white-noise term, fitted on standardized configurations. The epistemic variance of a prediction is the variance of the latent function, and the aleatoric variance is the fitted noise level.

We train one GP per service on its dataset $\mathcal{D}_i$, with a Matérn-5/2 kernel and an additive noise term. For a configuration x_i, which may be unobserved, the GP provides three quantities:

- the predicted mean execution time $m_i(x_i)$;
- the *epistemic* standard deviation $\sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i}(x_i)$, i.e., the uncertainty of the model about the mean execution time at x_i, which is large far away from the observed configurations and shrinks with more data; and
- the *aleatoric* standard deviation $\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}(x_i)$, i.e., the scatter of the execution times of individual items around their mean, which is a property of the service and does not shrink with more data.

The following two steps treat these two kinds of uncertainty differently. In the remainder of this section, we omit the argument x_i where it is clear from the context.

The number of observations per service is small in our setting, so we use exact GP inference; its cost is cubic in the number of observations N_i. For services that accumulate large amounts of operational data, the exact GP can be replaced by a sparse approximation (e.g., inducing-point methods) without changing the following steps, which only rely on the three quantities above.

Implementation. A benchmark run of a real service processes many items at one configuration. Instead of a single item per run, we use two statistics of each run as training targets: the mean of its execution times, and their spread, defined as (95th percentile − median) / 1.645, i.e., the standard deviation of a Gaussian with that median and 95th percentile. The mean of a run is a far less noisy observation of the mean execution time than a single item; in turn, it no longer reveals

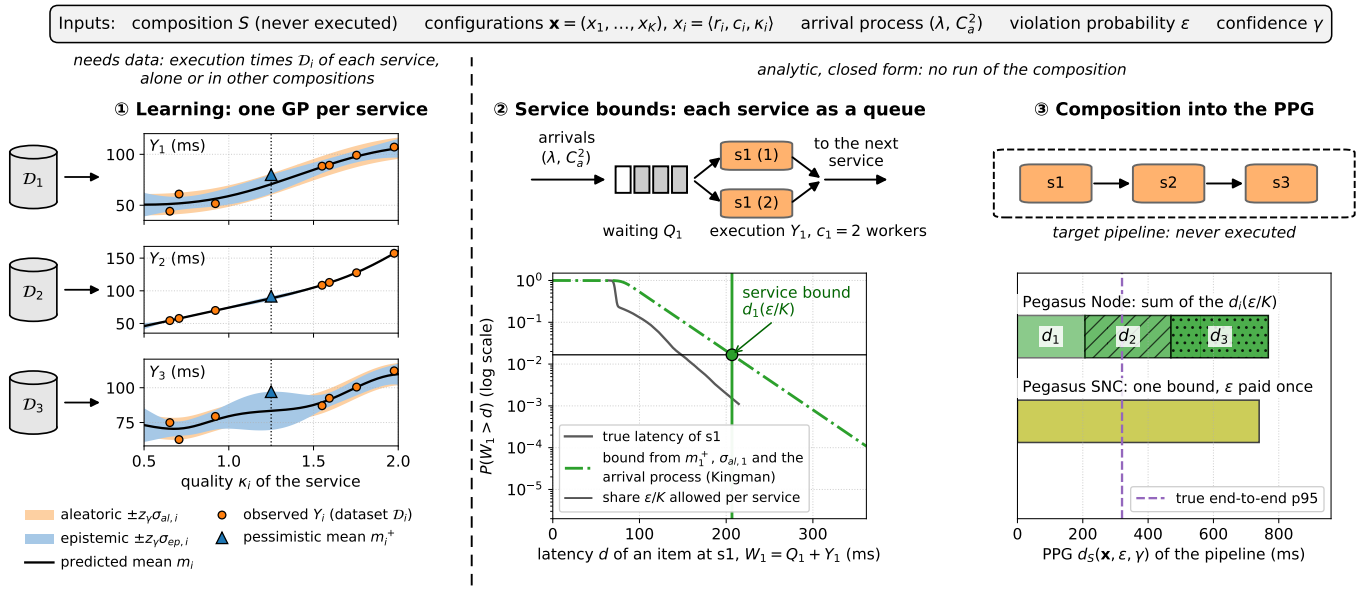


Fig. 2. Pegasus for a pipeline that has never been executed. ❶ One GP per service, trained only on that service's execution times $\mathcal{D}_i$, yields a pessimistic mean m_i^+ that grows with the epistemic uncertainty; ❷ Each service is bounded as a FIFO queue with c_i workers, which gives the service bound $d_i(\epsilon/K)$; ❸ The service bounds are composed into the PPG $d_S(\mathbf{x}, \epsilon, \gamma)$, either as their sum (Pegasus Node) or as one pipeline-wide bound (Pegasus SNC).

how much single items scatter, so a second GP per service predicts the spread and provides $\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}$. Both GPs are fitted on the logarithm of their target, because the knobs of a real service act multiplicatively on its execution time (e.g., a larger model at a higher resolution), which becomes additive on the logarithm. The shifts of Eqs. (6) and (11) are then relative, $m_i^+ = m_i\, e^{z_\gamma \sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i}}$ and $m_i^- = m_i\, e^{-z_\gamma \sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i}}$, with $\sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i}$ on the logarithmic scale, where $\sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i}$ also contains the scatter between repeated runs of the same configuration. The predicted spread enters the bounds without a margin of its own.

B. Service Bounds

The second step turns the model of a service into a bound on its latency $W_i = Q_i + Y_i$ under a given workload: a value $d_i(\epsilon)$ that the latency of an item exceeds with probability at most ϵ. Unlike the execution time, the latency includes the waiting time Q_i in the queue of the service, and therefore depends on how many items arrive.

Pessimistic Execution-Time Model. The two kinds of uncertainty act differently on a queue. The aleatoric scatter is independent from item to item, so over a busy period of many items it partly averages out. The epistemic error does not: if the model underestimates the mean execution time by 5 ms, *every* item at that configuration takes 5 ms longer, and the work of a busy period of 100 items grows by 500 ms. Adding both variances into the variance of a single item would treat this shared error as if it averaged out, and would underestimate the queue. We therefore let the epistemic uncertainty shift the mean, and keep only the aleatoric uncertainty as the variance per item:

$$m_i^+ = m_i + z_\gamma\, \sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i}, \qquad Y_i \sim \mathcal{N}\big(m_i^+,\, \sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}^2\big)\,, \tag{6}$$

where z_γ is the γ-quantile of the standard normal distribution (e.g., $z_\gamma \approx 1.64$ for $\gamma = 0.95$). According to the model, the true mean execution time lies below the *pessimistic mean* m_i^+ with probability γ; this is where the confidence level of the PPG enters. With Eq. (5), the MGF of the execution time is $M_i(\theta) = \exp(\theta m_i^+ + \frac{\theta^2}{2}\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}^2)$.

Waiting Time. The waiting time of an item at a FIFO service is the largest backlog of work that the items before it left behind. Under cyclic assignment (Assumption 2), each worker is a single-server queue whose gap between two items is the sum of c_i external gaps T. Since the gaps are independent (Assumption 5), Kingman's martingale bound [18] states that this backlog has an exponentially decaying tail,

$$\mathbb{P}(Q_i > w) \le e^{-\theta_i^* w}, \text{ with} \tag{7}$$

$$\theta_i^* = \sup\big\{\theta > 0 : M_i(\theta)\, \mathbb{E}\big[e^{-\theta T}\big]^{c_i} \le 1\big\}. \tag{8}$$

The *decay rate* θ_i^* (in $1/\mathrm{s}$) combines everything that makes a queue long: it decreases with a larger mean execution time, with a larger variance of the execution time, with a higher arrival rate, and with more variable arrivals. For Poisson arrivals at rate λ, for instance, $\mathbb{E}[e^{-\theta T}] = \lambda/(\lambda+\theta)$. If no $\theta > 0$ satisfies the condition, the service counts as overloaded and has no finite bound. Since the condition is evaluated with the pessimistic mean m_i^+, this can also happen for a service that is stable but whose mean execution time is not known precisely enough.

Implementation. The decay rate θ_i^* of Eq. (7) and the minimum in Eq. (16) are evaluated on a fixed logarithmic grid of θ; any θ below θ_i^* keeps Eq. (7) valid, so the grid can only make a bound larger. The service bound $d_i(\epsilon)$ is found by bisection on Eq. (9) and returns the upper end of the final interval.

Latency. The waiting time of an item depends only on the items before it, and is therefore independent of its own exe-

cution time. Combining Eq. (7) with the Gaussian execution time of Eq. (6) gives the tail of the latency in *closed form*,

$$\mathbb{P}(W_i > d) \le \bar{\Phi}\left(\frac{d - m_i^+}{\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}}\right) + e^{-\theta_i^*(d-m_i^+)+\frac{1}{2}(\theta_i^*\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i})^2}\,\Phi\left(\frac{d - m_i^+ - \theta_i^*\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}^2}{\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}}\right), \quad (9)$$

where Φ is the standard normal distribution function and $\bar{\Phi} = 1 - \Phi$. The first term is the probability that the execution time alone exceeds d; the second term accounts for the waiting time. The *service bound* $d_i(\epsilon)$ is the smallest d for which the right-hand side is at most ϵ; the right-hand side decreases in d, so $d_i(\epsilon)$ is found by bisection. Eq. (7) and the composition of Section IV-C only use the bound of Eq. (5); Eq. (9) additionally uses the Gaussian shape for the item's own execution time.

TODO: For sub-Gaussian but non-Gaussian Y_i: split $d = d_Y + d_Q$ and bound $\mathbb{P}(Y_i > d_Y) \le e^{-(d_Y - m_i^+)^2/(2\sigma_i^2)}$ and $\mathbb{P}(Q_i > d_Q) \le e^{-\theta_i^* d_Q}$ separately. Slightly looser; footnote or appendix.

TODO: Reread and simplify

Services Inside an Application. Only a limited set of frontend services receives an external arrival process; every subsequent service s_i receives the departures of its predecessor s_{i-1}. We bound such a service with the external arrival process in Eq. (7) (Assumption 6 in Section III-C), and tighten the bound if s_{i-1} has a single worker: two consecutive departures of s_{i-1} are then at least one execution time of s_{i-1} apart, and since a worker of s_i receives every c_i-th item, its gap between two items is at least c_i execution times of s_{i-1}. If s_{i-1} is slower than the c_i workers of s_i together, s_i can hardly build up a queue, whatever the external arrival rate is. Applying Kingman's bound to the execution times of s_i against this *minimum spacing* gives a second decay rate,

$$\theta_i^{\mathrm{s}} = \frac{2\left(c_i\, m_{i-1}^- - m_i^+\right)}{\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}^2 + c_i\,\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i-1}^2}, \text{ with} \quad (10)$$

$$m_{i-1}^- = m_{i-1} - z_\gamma\,\sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i-1}, \quad (11)$$

which is positive only if $c_i\, m_{i-1}^- > m_i^+$, i.e., if s_{i-1} is slower than all workers of s_i together, even when s_{i-1} enters with its *optimistic* mean m_{i-1}^- (a faster predecessor spaces the items less) and s_i with its pessimistic mean. A predecessor with several workers gives no such spacing, because it can release items out of order and at almost the same time; then $\theta_i^{\mathrm{s}} = 0$. Both tails bound the same waiting time, so the service bound uses the faster decay, i.e., $\max(\theta_i^*, \theta_i^{\mathrm{s}})$ in place of θ_i^* in Eq. (9). Eq. (10) treats the execution times of consecutive items at the two services as independent.

TODO: Integrate somewhere here

The MGF is the tool that makes these bounds composable: for every $\theta > 0$, Chernoff's bound gives $P(Y > d) \le e^{-\theta d} M_Y(\theta)$, so the MGF controls the tail, and the MGF of a sum of independent times is the product of their MGFs. The Laplace transform of the gaps in Assumption 5 is the MGF at $-\theta$.

C. Composition

The third step composes the models of the individual services into the PPG of the pipeline S. We provide two variants, which trade assumptions against tightness and which we both evaluate in Section V.

Composition per Service (*Pegasus Node*). The end-to-end latency is the sum of the latencies at the K services, $D_S = \sum_{i=1}^K W_i$. An item can only exceed the sum of the service bounds if it exceeds at least one of them. Hence, if every service is bounded at the violation probability ϵ/K,

$$d_S = \sum_{i=1}^K d_i\left(\frac{\epsilon}{K}\right) \quad \text{implies } (\Rightarrow) \quad (12)$$

$$\mathbb{P}(D_S > d_S) \le \sum_{i=1}^K \mathbb{P}\left(W_i > d_i\left(\frac{\epsilon}{K}\right)\right) \le \epsilon. \quad (13)$$

This union bound requires no information about how the latencies at different services depend on each other. It therefore remains valid if an item that is slow at one service is also slow at the next one (e.g., a large video frame), and although the queues of consecutive services are coupled. Its price is that every service is bounded further in the tail as the pipeline grows, and that every service pays for its own queue as if it stood alone, apart from the minimum spacing of Eq. (10). Each service bound is one closed formula, so the cost of evaluating d_S grows linearly with K.

Composition per Pipeline (*Pegasus SNC*). Stochastic Network Calculus (SNC) [9] composes the *service* that the nodes offer instead of their bounds: the pipeline is treated as one system that receives the external arrivals once, and what happens between the services is absorbed into the composition. In the MGF domain, the end-to-end latency of a pipeline of FIFO services obeys

$$\mathbb{P}(D_S > d) \le e^{-\theta d} \prod_{i=1}^K \frac{M_i(\theta)}{1 - \phi_i(\theta)}, \text{ with} \quad (14)$$

$$\phi_i(\theta) = M_i(\theta)\,\mathbb{E}\left[e^{-\theta T}\right]^{c_i} < 1, \quad (15)$$

for every $\theta > 0$, where each factor is the latency moment of one service: its execution-time MGF, inflated by the queue that the load $\phi_i(\theta)$ causes. Solving for the latency at the violation probability ϵ and choosing the best θ yields

$$d_S = \min_{\theta > 0} \frac{1}{\theta}\left[\sum_{i=1}^K \ln\frac{M_i(\theta)}{1 - \phi_i(\theta)} - \ln\epsilon\right]. \quad (16)$$

The derivation of Eq. (14) assumes that items leave every service in the order they arrived, which holds for services with a single worker. A service with several workers can release items out of order; for such pipelines, we use Eqs. (14)–(16) with the factor c_i in Eq. (15) as an approximation and validate it empirically in Section V, whereas *Pegasus Node* remains a guarantee.

In contrast to Eq. (12), the violation probability is not split: the term $-\ln\epsilon$ is paid once for the whole pipeline, which is the "pay bursts only once" property of network calculus. Moreover, Eq. (16) makes no assumption about the arrivals

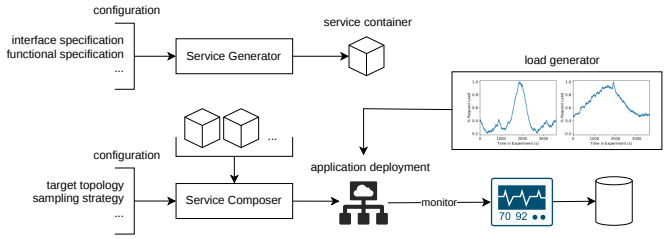


Fig. 3. High-level architecture of the experimental environment: the *service generator* creates containerized services according to a desired interface and functionality; the *service composer* ...

inside the pipeline, so Assumption 6 is not needed. In return, a single parameter θ is shared by all services, so one service close to saturation loosens the bound of the whole pipeline, and the product in Eq. (14) requires that the execution times of an item are independent between the services. If they are not, Hölder's inequality restores the validity for any dependence: service s_i enters Eq. (14) with its variance multiplied by an exponent $p_i \geq 1$, where $\sum_i 1/p_i = 1$. This makes the bound looser and its evaluation more expensive, because the exponents are tuned per configuration; we report it as an ablation.

TODO: What needs to be shared in the two variants?

Resulting Guarantee.

Both variants return a latency bound that satisfies Eq. (4) whenever the pessimistic mean of every service lies above its true mean execution time. Each service fulfills this with confidence γ, according to its model. For the whole pipeline, all K services must fulfill it simultaneously, which holds with confidence of at least $1 - K(1-\gamma)$; choosing the per-service level as $1-(1-\gamma)/K$ would restore the confidence γ for the pipeline, at the price of larger pessimistic means. We apply γ per service and report in Section V how often the resulting bounds cover the measured latency quantile of the pipeline.

Why This Combination. The three steps depend on each other. Point-estimate models (e.g., neural networks or gradient-boosted trees) provide no epistemic uncertainty and thus no pessimistic mean, which is what protects the bound at configurations that were never observed. The GP provides it, and separates it from the scatter between items. Its Gaussian form gives the MGF of Eq. (5) in closed form, and the MGF is exactly the quantity from which both the martingale bound and SNC derive the tail of a queue. As a result, the service bounds and their composition are evaluated from closed-form expressions, without simulating the pipeline and without sampling.

V. Evaluation

We evaluate Pegasus through a series of eight experiments that show its accuracy and complexity in comparison to baseline methods. As a first step, we generate a set of applications (*CV*, *Audio*, *Lidar*), for which Pegasus

A. Experimental Setup

Service Generation. To evaluate generalization across structural dimensions, we evaluate unseen service configurations, unseen service compositions, and their combination. This requires an ample set of services and service compositions; for this, we combine an existing set of microservices and configuration interfaces from prior work [26] and augment it through LLM-based code generation.

Baselines. We compare *Pegasus* against five baselines that all operate under the same constraint: each method is trained only on observations of the individual services and never on a run of the evaluated composition. Hence, methods produce an end-to-end latency for an *unseen* composition S with $K = |S|$ services, which we compare with the ground truth, i.e., the measured $(1-\epsilon)$ quantile of the end-to-end latency of S. The baselines form three groups, which differ in what they observe per service and in how they account for queueing:

- **Execution-time models without queueing (*GP Sum*, *DNN Sum*):** one model per service predicts the mean and the standard deviation of the execution time from the service configuration; the end-to-end latency is the $(1-\epsilon)$ quantile of the sum of these execution times, assuming that they are Gaussian and independent between services. *GP Sum* uses the same GPs as *Pegasus*, so the two differ only in the composition; *DNN Sum* replaces each GP with a feed-forward neural network that reports the standard deviation of its training residuals. Both ignore the arrival process and thus represent the naive composition of per-service predictions.

  TODO: As in Fluxion [19] we must argue that this is a common method for predicting end-to-end latency.
- **Queueing formula (*Kingman*):** the predicted mean and variance of the GPs enter the Allen–Cunneen approximation of the mean waiting time in a G/G/c queue [4], which reduces to Kingman's formula [17] for a single worker, combined with an exponential waiting-time tail [15]. This gives the $(1-\epsilon)$ latency quantile of each service, and the quantiles are added. *Kingman* represents classical queueing analysis on top of a learned model: it accounts for queueing, but it is an approximation and not a bound, and it takes the GP predictions at face value, without a margin for epistemic uncertainty.
- **Learned latency quantiles (*Quantile Union*, *Conformal*):** instead of execution times, these baselines learn the latency of a service under load. Each service is monitored in isolation under the arrival process of the workload, and one GP per service predicts its $(1-\epsilon/K)$ latency quantile from the service configuration; the K predictions are added, which splits the violation budget ϵ over the services as a union bound. This corresponds to the modular learning of latency percentiles in *Fluxion* [19], with every model restricted to data of its own service. *Quantile Union* uses these point predictions directly. *Conformal* adds a split-conformal step: a part of the training configurations is set aside, and each prediction is multiplied by a correction factor calibrated on that part, such that it covers the latency quantile of the service with a chosen confidence. Both need a load test per service and training configuration, whereas *Pegasus* needs execution times only, and both assume that a service

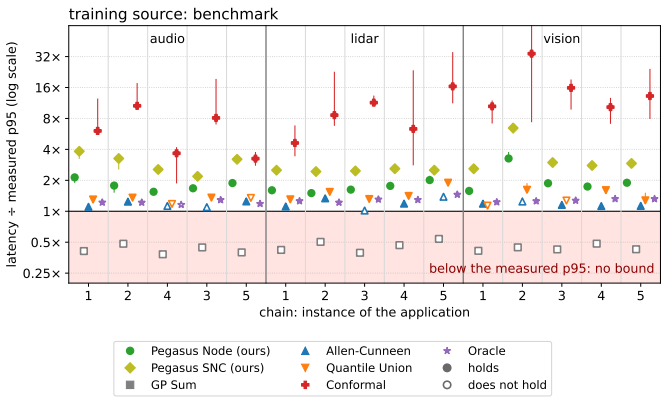


Fig. 4. Enter Caption

receives the same arrival process inside the composition as in isolation.

As a reference, we report an *Oracle*, the union bound over the *measured* $(1-\epsilon/K)$ latency quantiles of the services inside the composition. It uses the ground truth and is therefore not a competitor; it shows the tightest result that any method splitting the budget ϵ over the services can reach, so the remaining distance to a method is caused by its per-service bounds and not by the union bound.

Besides the baselines, we ablate the composition step of *Pegasus* on identical GP models: (1) the union bound over per-service bounds, with Chernoff-based or martingale-based bounds, each with and without propagating the departure process of the preceding service, and (2) the network service curve, with and without Hölder's inequality, which extends its validity to dependent services. Finally, the experiment on fine-tuning with end-to-end samples (Section V-C1) is the only one that includes baselines trained on runs of the composition itself: the sum of per-service latency quantiles measured inside the composition, and a *Fluxion*-style chain of GPs that passes predicted latency percentiles from one service to the next [19].

B. Coverage and Tightness of Service Bounds

1) Base Case: This will use most of the baselines from above to evaluate the maturity of our ideas vs. existing techniques.

2) Varying Evidence per Service: This makes use of the presented sampling strategies. The services are executed somewhere under an arbitrary service composition that is different from the target composition. We gradually train the PPGs with more of this data and see if this has an impact on the quality of the unseen target composition.

3) Varying Chain Depth: We evaluate how the validity, empirical coverage rate, and tightness of the derived PPGs scale with increasing depth of a map-reduce application. By evaluating synthetic and real chains across varying lengths $|S| \in \{1, 2, 5, 10, 20, 50\}$, we assess whether the composed bounds remain sufficiently tight and actionable for downstream optimization without having their bounds degraded.

4) Varying Load and Arrival Pattern: Here we will use different arrival pattern (e.g., periodic, random (= Poisson), and batching) and different arrival rates (e.g., diurnal or bursty with custom range). I already explored this once and found that we can characterize each of these arrival processes through the squared coefficient of variation (C_a^2) as defined in Eq. (2)

5) Varying Tail Behaviors: Here I can look at services that have a different tail behavior (e.g., increasingly heavy/light tails) and how this impacts the quality of the guarantee.

6) Varying Percentiles: Optionally, I could also look into different percentile guarantees and show where each method is more/less accurate.

C. Iterative Optimization of Service Bounds

I would integrate this into a use case, where we have to compose increasingly better applications using this method.

1) Fine-Tuning Bounds with E2E Samples: Our focus is giving a rough guarantee *before* deploying it e2e, so this means the best we can do as soon as it goes e2e is to show that our model provides an initial accuracy boost that likely vanishes over time.

2) Inferring Faster Service Compositions: This can go into two directions, first, we can optimize the service configuration according to the model, and second, we can improve the service composition.

For the first one, we can take *Fluxion* [19] (cf. Section 5.1.3) as inspiration, where they also used the model paired with an external optimizer to show how their model enables better performance optimization. They simply compared the different guarantee models (theirs, a plain GP, and a DNN) for coupled with different optimizers; this we can do as well, and it is also a nice cut between the guarantee (our contribution) and the external optimizer.

For the second one, it might be a bit more complex because we have not talked a lot about the composition mechanism, but I would design it like the first one: we assume some composition mechanism that is external to us and we gradually show that by using our guarantees it can create better service composition. I think that this is the real deal because it repeatedly looks into unseen configurations, but it also the most complex evaluation. In any case, I think that a genetic algorithm could be the best choice here, because it builds a population of potential solutions and then iteratively improves them through sampling. But we do NOT have to include multiple rounds of benchmarking, but only one. The distinction would be:

- **single round**: we build a population of compositions and grade them according to different guarantees (ours vs. baselines). We repeat this step in a genetic algorithm until we have a solution for every guarantee. Then we benchmark these solutions and look at their fitness.
- **multiple round**: as above, but we use the empirical samples we captured from the benchmark and run the genetic algorithm (planning) and benchmarking again and again until we converge to a satisfying result. This we keep for future work at NSDI hehe

VI. Discussion

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A. Limitations

Heavy-Tailed Execution Times. The performance of distributed systems is known to show heavy-tailed behavior, e.g., during garbage collection. *Pegasus* requires sub-Gaussian execution times (Assumption 4). If a Gaussian is fitted to a service with a heavier tail, the bound stays accurate where queueing dominates the latency, because a long queue depends mainly on the mean and the variance of the execution time; it becomes optimistic where the tail of a single execution dominates, i.e., at low utilization, for very regular arrivals, and for high percentiles. The per-service composition is affected more strongly in deep pipelines, as it bounds every service at ϵ/K.

Two extensions keep the framework applicable. First, services in production enforce timeouts; an execution time that is cut off at a timeout τ is bounded and therefore sub-Gaussian, so the guarantee holds for the service as deployed.

TODO: Draft of the mechanism: with a hard timeout, $Y_i \leq \tau$ always, and Bennett's inequality bounds the MGF from the variance and the range, which is tighter than a Gaussian with the range as scale. Without a hard timeout: cap at a high quantile and reserve a part of ϵ for items beyond the cap; this needs a proof for the items in the same busy period.

Second, network calculus has been extended to heavy-tailed processes with power-law instead of exponential envelopes [20]; the resulting bounds decay polynomially, are considerably looser, and lose the closed forms that make *Pegasus* fast to evaluate, which is why we do not adopt them.

Sampling from Evaluation Rounds. The idea was that we can drastically simplify experiments by not propagating decisions (e.g., *where* to explore) back to the services, but instead use the grading function to sample from all conducted runs. Given the coverage of the solution space, we can bound the inaccuracy this creates by finding the largest distance between two points, or a point and the parameter bounds.

VII. Conclusion & Future Work

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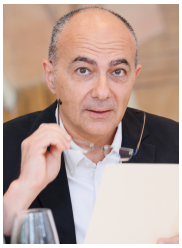
Milos Gravara ...



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POTENTIAL APPENDIX

- List of the services and their states and configuration knobs in more detail. This can be clusters of service types, as for *Fluxion* in [19].
- Description of the code artifact, or at least a pointer to the extended description in the README there.